the new India. He was accused of rape. Accused, convicted in sessions, then acquitted. And acquitted again, finally, by the Supreme Court. And while his final acquittal meant that he did not have to endure the mandatory minimum of seven years' imprisonment, he did spend two years in Tihar. Going by his powerfully immersive account of life in Tihar, two years in that hell may be enough to satisfy even his most tireless detractors.

However, all that is incidental to the achievement of *The Tihar Players*. Because the uplifting story that Farooqui tells is little short of a miracle. An astonishingly creative dramatic talent, Farooqui turned to the practice of theatre in order to preserve some semblance of sanity amid the deadly monotony of prison life. He secured permission to run a theatre workshop with his fellow inmates. Despite recurrent difficulties, both with the prison bureaucracy, but also from his fellows, he was able to elicit the residual spark of humanity in his company of derelicts. Multiple performances, not only to prison audiences, but also in the wider world beyond, are a poignant tribute to the transcendent power of creativity.

Despite difficulties with the prison bureaucracy, FAROOQUI IS ABLE TO ELICIT THE RESIDUAL spark of humanity in his company of derelicts

Farooqui's recourse to the practice of his forgotten faith has a significance that goes beyond the fact that it brought a measure of order to the featureless desert of prison time. Namaz, Ramazan, Eid, all that, and the recurrent withdrawal into a contemplative subjectivity, provided this former atheist much-needed solace. But Farooqui is a writer, and his is, ultimately, a writer's religion. While the Kalma requires believers to bear witness to God, Farooqui's god assures the believer—no matter how derelict or destitute—that *he* is witnessed, seen, remembered. Maybe that's why they send writers to prison, so that even the destitute and the outcasts may somewhere be remembered, be seen. Those of us who have been fortunate enough to have seen Mahmood Farooqui perform his *dastaan* of Karna, the ultimate outcast, will find it entirely fitting that he wrote this in Tihar! ■

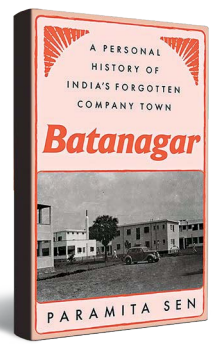
—Alok Rai

Working within all this, Schaller translated his research into conservation action, helping secure millions of acres for protection. His legacy also lies in the biologists he influenced: Jane Goodall and Dian Fossey are among the better-known names, though Schaller was committed to nurturing "home-grown" scientists. These embody the larger lesson of Schaller's life: to put the subject before the scientist, and to serve the lands and species they studied. *Homesick for a World Unknown* is also a powerful tribute to an ethically engaged way of doing science that may now be as endangered as the species it seeks to understand. ■

—Prerna Singh Bindra

SHOE TOWN CHRONICLES

A NOSTALGIC HISTORY OF **BATANAGAR**, AN INTRINSIC PART OF THE STORY OF A FOREIGN BRAND THAT BECAME AN INDIAN HOUSEHOLD NAME



BATANAGAR: A PERSONAL HISTORY OF INDIA'S FORGOTTEN COMPANY TOWN
By Paramita Sen
PAN MACMILLAN
₹399; 225 pages

It's often easy to forget that Bata is not an Indian brand. The footwear company has its origins in Zlín, in the Czech Republic. When it arrived in colonial India in the 1920s, it found a second home in Batanagar, a short hop from Calcutta. This became the hub of design and manufacturing for a distribution network that spread as far as East Africa, China and Southeast Asia. This was also where a diverse, multilingual community blossomed. Paramita Sen grew up in this closed neighbourhood and, through her childhood memories, relives the journey of the shoe manufacturer in *Batanagar: A Personal History of India's Forgotten Company Town*.

A year into their India operations, Bata had replaced Japanese plimsoll imports through a crafty integration of foreign technology and local workforce. During WWII, Batanagar produced everything—from boots to belts to equip the Allied forces. During Partition, they absorbed refugees in their factories—Batanagar in India and Batapur in Pakistan—helping them start a new life.

Post-Independence, Bata established itself as a foreign brand with an Indian heart, omnipresent across India. Batanagar was where it all unfolded, which, to the author's dismay, is a shadow of the vibrant locale it once was. The engaging book keeps those memories alive, a breezy read for a lazy Sunday afternoon. ■

—Shail Desai